BUSH HILL CUBS – Program		
16.10.2026	Theme: **Bush Hill Cubs, how does your garden grow?**	Raksha
TIME	**ACTIVITY**	**LEADER / EQUIP**
2.40 **10 min**	**Opening: Grand Howl** **Register** **Inspection – Scarves**	**Akela**
Before we start our Gardening Badge, let's head outside to let off STEAM!		
2.50 **10 min**	**STEAM RELEASE GAME:** Tug Rope Divide Pack into two groups. Each tugs on a rope to try get the marked m middle of the the rope over the line.	**Jordan and Hathi** Marked rope Cross over points
Change the world? Grow a garden! **Not sure how? Let's find out!**		
3:00 **25 mins**	**Gardening Badge: Bases (8min each)** **Divide Pack into three groups.** ***(Please engage the Cubs conversationally on these points. Ask for and discuss their ideas, and towards the end of the allotted time, make sure all the information has been covered, adding in anything they may not have thought of one their own.)*** **Base 1: How to attract birds to your garden** **(Badge Requirement # 7)** **Base 2: What do plants need to grow?** **(Badge Requirement #2)** **Base 3: What plants are best suited for our area?** **(Badge Requirement #1)**	**Raksha** (Information included below.) **Dani** **Jordan** **Kaa**
3:20 **5 min**	**Circle / Testing Game: True or False** **Cubs stand in a circle. Leader asks questions. Cubs <u>stand</u> for TRUE or <u>sit</u> for FALSE.**	**Akela** **Questions and Answers**
Gardening is thirsty work! Time for juice and a snack!		
3.25 **5 min**	**Juice & Biscuits**	**PH**
Let's head outside and grow some vegetables and herbs! Some we will take home today, others we will nurture here and we can harvest and share as it is ready!		

3.30 **20 min**	**Bases:** **Planting Vegetable and herb seedlings into planters** **Growing a new plant from an old plant** Plant vegetable and herb seedlings into the planters, and planting onion ends and origanum cuttings into egg carton segments **Badge Requirement # 5** **Badge Requirement # 8**	**Akela / Hathi** **Jordan / Raksha** Seedlings, trowels, egg boxes, cuttings, compost **(PH to please help clean up afterwards.)**
Story time!		
3:50 **15 min**	**YARN: In the Professor's Garden**	**Raksha**
4.10 **10 min**	**Closing Prayer** **Raffle Winner** **Helping Hand** **Badges** **Beans** **Announcements**	**Akela**

BEANS:

RED	BLUE	WHITE	GREEN	PURPLE	YELLOW

Cub Gardening Badge

Badge requirements



Do any FIVE of the following:

1. Find out what types of plants are best suited to grow in your area. *
2. Explain what plants need to grow. *
3. Explain how you can help plants to grow without water.
4. Grow flowers in a bed or in a window box.
5. Plant and grow at least two vegetables for use by your family. *
6. Grow some flowers or vegetables in a solution of chemicals. (Note: A letter must be produced from a parent or adult).
7. Find out how to attract birds to your garden by planting the right type of plants. *
8. Grow a new plant from old ones; either by cuttings or by seeds or pips. *

* Requirements covered in this programme

Badge Requirement # 1: What plants are best suited to our area? (Highveld)

Johannesburg is on the Highveld, a high, mostly flat area that is naturally a grassland region. We experience warm, wet summers, and cold, dry winters with frost, and we need to choose plants that grow well in these conditions.

Choosing plants and trees that grow naturally in our area, also called indigenous plants, will help:
-conserve our precious water resources,
-protect soil structure,, attract birds, butterflies and other creatures to our garden and other green spaces, and,
-preserve wildlife that is struggling to adapt and thrive in our rapidly urbanising area.

We need a variety of plants including flowering plants, grasses, succulents, ground covers, shrubs, and trees. When choosing these plants, we must consider what kind of temperature and rainfall they need.

Many succulents are from areas that have hot, dry summers and wet winters, like Cape Town, and these plants will rot in Johannesburg's wet summers and struggle in our cold, dry winters. Certain aloes and vygies grow very well here; a book for our local conditions, a local garden centre, and the internet could help us choose wisely.

Many plants and trees can't tolerate frost. If we want to plant these, we need to carefully choose a protected area in our gardens, or choose plants that are better suited to cold, dry, frosty winters.

Different kinds of grasses are good to include in our gardens because Johannesburg is naturally part of a grassland area. This doesn't mean that big, lush green lawns are best! Lawns use a lot of water, require maintenance like trimming and mowing adds to air pollution (electric and petrol lawnmowers both cause air and noise pollution), and require unnatural fertilisers that pollute and poison precious groundwater sources. If we want a lawn, we should ask the advice of a landscaper who knows and cares about our local climate conditions, find out ways to water it wisely and fertilise it naturally, and could also consider decreasing the size of our lawns to include more space to grow flowers, shrubs, trees and even food. There is even a a book called 'FOOD NOT LAWNS' that encourages people to grow food rather than environmentally unfriendly lawns!

Some examples of plants that grow well here are:

Spekboom
Mountain aloes
Agapanthus
Strelitzia (also called the Bird of Paradise)
Wild Garlic
The "hen and chicken" plant, also called the "spider plant" grows well under trees and in shady areas

Sweet potato vines make excellent ground covers, need very little water, can tolerate full, hot sun, and we can eat the leaves as well as the roots.
Herbs like rosemary and thyme attract bees, have low water needs and high tolerance for full sun, and have medicinal and culinary uses.

For trees, the magnificent white stinkwood is a good choice for a space that can take a large tree, while the karee, wild olive, and yellowwood are smaller trees that grow well in our climate.

We should always try grow some FOOD, and in summer tomatoes, peppers, pumpkins and squash as well as most herbs grow very well, while in winter we can grow beautiful cabbages, broccoli, cauliflower, spinach and Swiss chard, leeks and onions. Many fruit trees grow well with a little care too, like citrus (oranges, lemons, limes), avocado, and peach trees.

Badge Requirement # 2: What do plants need to grow?

The Essential Needs of Plants

- **Light:** Plants use light energy (from the sun or special grow lights) for **photosynthesis**, the process of turning carbon dioxide and water into food (glucose).
- **Water:** Roots absorb water from the soil. Water carries vital minerals through the plant and keeps the plant firm and upright (turgor pressure).
- **Air:** Plants take in **carbon dioxide (CO_2)** through their leaves to make food, and they use **oxygen (O_2)** in their roots to breathe (respiration).
- **Nutrients:** Plants pull essential minerals like **nitrogen**, **phosphorus**, and **potassium** from the soil to build leaves, grow strong roots, and fight disease.
- **Space:** Plants need room above and below ground so their roots can spread out and their leaves can reach the light without crowding each other
- **Temperature:** Plants need warmth to grow and thrive. Many plants enter a period of dormancy during winter, when they lose their leaves and almost seem to die, but when the temperature starts rising in early spring, new leaves flowers, and fruit emerge from the woody parts of the plant. These plants are called “deciduous plants”.

Badge Requirement # 7: How to attract Birds to your garden

To attract birds to your garden, you need to provide four key things: food, water, shelter, and a safe environment.

1. Provide Diverse Food Sources

- **Seeds and Grains**
- **Suet and Mealworms:** Hang suet blocks or offer dried mealworms to attract insect-eating birds like robins, starlings, thrushes, and woodpeckers.
- **Nectar and Fruit:** Plant red, orange, and yellow indigenous flowers (like aloes, wild dagga, and red-hot pokers) for nectar-feeding birds, or put out fresh fruit like over-ripe apples and berries for thrushes

2. Offer Clean Water

- **Shallow Bird Baths:** Provide a wide, shallow bird bath (no deeper than 2 to 3 inches) with a rough surface or stones so birds can grip and stand safely.
- **Moving Water:** Add a dripper, bubbler, or small fountain. The sound and movement of rippling water attract birds from a distance and signal that it is fresh.
- **Maintenance:** Change the water daily and scrub the container weekly to stop algae growth and prevent the spread of disease

3. Create Natural Shelter and Nesting Sites

- **Layered Plants:** Design your garden with a mix of tall trees, medium shrubs, and lower ground covers. Dense, evergreen shrubs offer year-round protection from weather and predators.
- **Leave Wild Areas:** Keep a corner of your garden a bit messy by piling up fallen leaves, logs, and compost. This creates a natural habitat for insects, worms, and grubs, which feed many local bird species.
- **Nest Boxes:** Install wooden nest boxes for cavity-nesting birds, facing them north or east to protect them from harsh midday sun and driving rain

4. Ensure Safety

- **Avoid Chemicals:** Stop using chemical pesticides, herbicides, and slug pellets. These kill off the natural insects birds need to eat and can poison the birds directly.
- **Manage Pets:** Keep cats indoors—especially at dawn, dusk, and night—or fit them with a bell to give birds an early warning.
- **Protect Windows:** Position feeders either very close to windows (within 3 feet) or far away (more than 30 feet) so birds do not build up fatal speed if they fly toward the glass reflection.

TRUE OR FALSE GAME:

1. Plants need light to grow? (T)

2. To attract birds to your garden, you should let your pet cat play outside. (F)

3. Here in Johannesburg, we should plant trees that need a lot of water in winter. (F)

4. Plants need wind to grow? (F)

5. A plant that loses its leaves in winter is called a “deciduous plant”? (T)

6. Nesting boxes help attract birds to your garden. (T)

7. We have a cold, wet climate so we must grow plants that like cold, wet weather. (F)

8: Plants need air to grow. (T)

9. Bird feeders with seeds and fruit help attract birds to your garden. (T)

10. Plants like to grow in cold, dark places. (F)

11. Birds prefer shallow water rather than deep pools of water. (T)

12. We live in a coastal area so we should grow plants that like to grow at the beach. (F)

13. A garden with different kinds of trees and plants attracts birds. (T)

14. Plants from Alaska are well suited to our Johannesburg gardens. (F)

15. If we put fruit into our bird feeders, we might attract dodos and ostriches. (F)

16. To help attract birds and other creatures to our gardens, we should spray poisons and chemicals onto our plants often. (F)

17. Plants that grow naturally in a particular area are called “indigenous plants”. (T)

18. Growing indigenous plants helps conserve water and protect soil. (T)

19. We should grow many plants from many different countries. (F)

20. Here is Johannesburg, we should include succulents and grasses into our gardens. (T)

21. Lush, green lawns are pretty but not water-wise or environmentally friendly. (T)